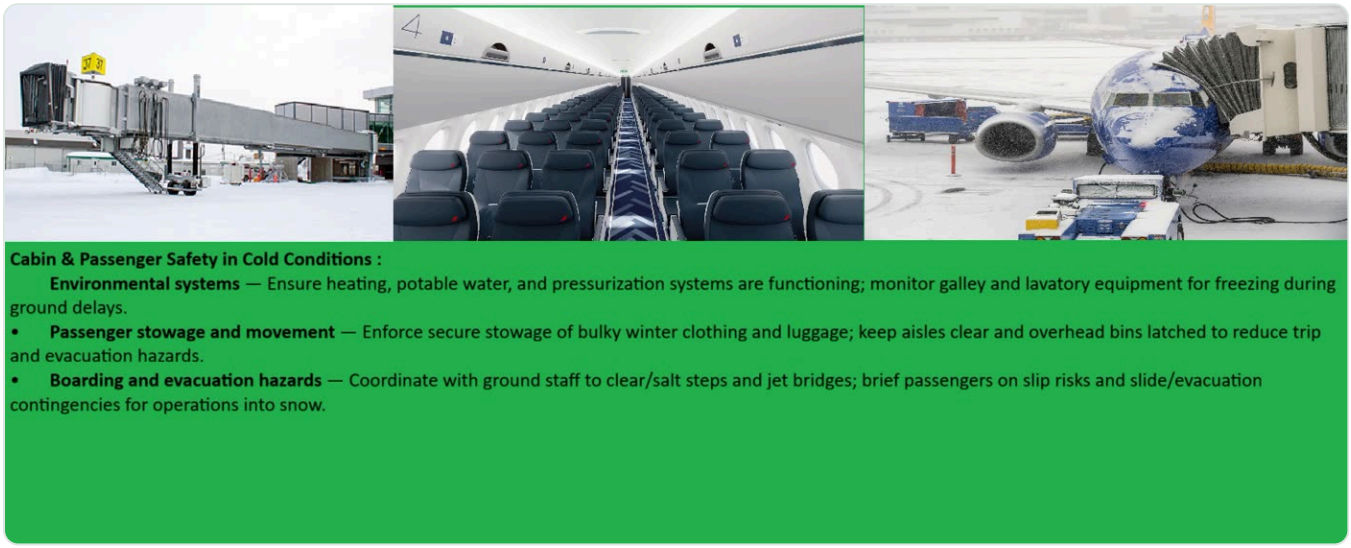
MODULE 6 · OPERATIONS AND HUMAN FACTORS

Lesson 26: Cabin and Passenger Safety in Cold Conditions

Lesson 26 of 30 · about 7 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify cabin and passenger hazards in winter operations.
- Describe the role of cabin crew in reporting contamination.
- Plan for an evacuation in cold conditions.



Cabin safety in winter: boarding, de-icing announcements and reporting what you see.

Boarding and disembarking

- Steps, jet bridges and ramps can be icy. Make sure they are treated and lit, and have handrails. Remind passengers to hold on.
- Keep doors closed when not in use to preserve cabin heat and keep snow out.
- Glycol on the ramp is very slippery. Passengers walking on the apron must be kept away from de-icing areas.

During de-icing

- Inform the passengers before de-icing starts. They will hear noise, see fluid on the windows, and may smell glycol.
- Cabin crew must report **smoke, unusual smells or fumes** to the flight deck at once.
- Passengers should stay seated with seat belts fastened, because the aircraft may move soon after treatment.

Cabin crew as observers

Cabin crew can often see the wings better than the pilots. A clear company procedure is needed so that cabin crew know:

- **what to look for** — snow building up, a dull surface, ice on leading edges;
- **how to report it** — immediately, directly to the commander, even during busy phases;
- that their report will be welcomed and acted on.

The Dryden inquiry (Lesson 30) found that cabin crew and passengers had seen snow on the wings, but this information did not reach the flight deck.

Evacuation in cold conditions

- Slides inflate more slowly and may be less stable in strong wind and on icy surfaces.
- Overwing exits and wing surfaces may be covered with ice, snow or fluid — extremely slippery.
- Passengers will be outside, often without coats. Move them away from the aircraft, keep groups together and get them to shelter as soon as possible. Watch for hypothermia, especially in children and elderly passengers.
- Communicate with the airport emergency services about warm shelter and transport.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Treat and light steps and ramps; keep passengers away from de-icing areas.
- Cabin crew report fumes and any contamination they see — immediately.
- Cold evacuation: slower slides, icy wings, and hypothermia risk after evacuation.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

A cabin crew member sees snow building up on the wing while the aircraft is holding for take-off. What should they do?

A. Wait until after take-off to mention it

B. Report it immediately and directly to the commander

C. Tell the passengers to stay calm

D. Write it in the cabin log

Answer: B. Possible wing contamination before take-off is safety-critical information. It must be reported immediately and directly to the commander.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.